Unfortunately, Udham Singh had a farcical defence. It was bungled by the rank opportunism and incompetence of Krishna Menon, himself widely seen as an early Indian hero of the pre-Independence freedom struggle. Described as ‘calculating’,[16] Krishna Menon was a forceful and highly abrasive man, driven always by an ambition to prove himself. He was a close friend of Nehru and destined in the views of many to be the second most powerful man in India after Nehru became prime minister. He ‘had initially wanted to dissociate himself from Udham’s actions’ and had ‘repudiated the shootings within hours of the event’.[17] What then appeared to change his mind was that ‘Gandhi and Nehru had been locked in delicate negotiations with the British and wanted desperately to promote a counternarrative to that of Sir Michael O’Dwyer’, which suggested that ‘Indians were not violent barbarians’.[18] However, ‘when it became clear how much publicity Udham’s case was getting and how much support he had within British Indian circles, Krishna Menon appeared to rethink his own position. If there was to be a trial, it would be a very high-profile affair, and Krishna Menon wanted in’.[19] Then, ‘with no legal standing in the case, Krishna Menon’ informed everyone that ‘he was now running Udham’s defence’.[20] In the event, ‘Krishna Menon did not care about Udham’s motivations or state of mind’[21] and his involvement ‘would allow him to steer proceedings in a direction that best helped his friends Nehru and Gandhi in India. If it did not serve their interest to have Udham’s nationalism dragged into court, he could keep it out’.[22] When Udham Singh was sentenced to death by hanging, and others clamoured to have his sentence commuted to life imprisonment, ‘Krishna Menon did nothing at all’.[23] Upon Independence in 1947, Menon was appointed by the Congress Party as India’s first high commissioner to the United Kingdom.

Documents from the Public and Judicial Department of New Scotland Yard confirm that after two hours of deliberation, the jury returned a verdict of ‘Guilty of Murder’. It is said that ‘Singh then started to read some sort of statement written on paper but soon gave up and addressed the court in very stilted phrases which were difficult to follow’. Nevertheless, ‘he was heard to say, however, that he was not afraid to die and that when he had gone,